

Subject Code	ENGL5041
Subject Title	Sociolinguistics at Work
Credit Value	3
Level	5
Pre-requisite/ Co-requisite/ Exclusion	None
Objectives	This course trains students in core theoretical perspectives on language and communication with respect to power and social dynamics. As perceptions of language and the linguistic world are rooted in culturally informed worldviews, one of the primary aims of this course entails examining beliefs about language through socio-culturally specific lenses to explore some of the resulting inequalities. This undertaking helps bring local perspectives to the fore and provides a framework for examining the ways in which language and other communicative resources are managed in workplaces and by workers. An additional aim of the subject includes investigating the link between communication and economics. Specifically, we explore the impact of communication on socioeconomic mobility, the neoliberal world order, and the commodification of communicative resources by neoliberal workers and workplaces. In the final weeks of the class, course material will venture beyond language to address the growing research focus on embodied sociolinguistics, materiality, and affect in workplace communication. By integrating these concepts into their education, students can develop a comprehensive communication skill set that prepares them for the complexities of modern workplaces. They will be better positioned to navigate diverse linguistic and cultural settings, create inclusive environments, and transform their communication into a powerful tool for personal and professional growth.
Intended Learning Outcomes	Upon completion of the subject, students will be able to: a. critically discuss linguistic worldviews as cultural phenomena, cultivating an understanding of the ways in which these influence interpersonal relationships, team dynamics, and perceptions of professionalism in the workplace b. demonstrate familiarity with core theoretical perspectives of language planning and policy, language attitudes, linguistic capital, translanguaging, and multicompetence c. explain how language can become a source of discrimination and inequality, improving students' capacity to become more inclusive communicators and reducing biases that may hinder collaboration and innovation at the workplace

	d. critically discuss the relationship between communication and the economy, contributing to future employees' understanding of the means through which power is negotiated and asserted at the workplace and ultimately aiding their own upward trajectory at the workplace e. show leadership in identifying the role of linguistic and extra-linguistic communicative resources under neoliberalism, which can enhance future employees' ability to create compelling brand narratives that target both company-internal and company-external audiences f. work creatively, both independently and as a member of a team, to examine socio-culturally grounded case studies g. demonstrate a global outlook and an awareness of linguistic diversity with respect to gender and social class, potentially improving team dynamics and ensuring that all voices at future employees' workplaces are heard and valued.
Subject Synopsis/ Indicative Syllabus	Course content will emphasize the mastery of the themes listed below both as theoretical concepts and as lenses through which to examine communication among workers and in workplaces. Students' ability to discern these communication dynamics in the workplace will improve their ability to navigate multilingual environments, adhere to corporate language standards, and effectively communicate with diverse teams. • Language planning and policy • Language attitudes and discrimination • Language and neoliberalism • Language and socioeconomic mobility • The commodification of language and semiotics • Translanguaging and poly/metrolinguistics • Gendered communication • Embodied and multimodal forms of communication
Teaching/Learning Methodology	Short interactive activities will be incorporated into the lectures at regular intervals. Following the lectures, some class time will be devoted to longer interactive activities that allow students to apply the information learned during the lecture to novel contexts. Through prepared presentations, students will elaborate on this material by examining its relevance to settings and languages with which they are deeply familiar. The case study final project allows students to extend their analysis into fully developed reflections on the concepts vis-à-vis these settings and languages, allowing them to contextualize novel findings within the existing relevant literature.

Assessment Methods in Alignment with Intended Learning Outcomes	<table><tr><th rowspan="2">Specific assessment methods/tasks</th><th rowspan="2">% weighting</th><th>a</th><th>b</th><th>c</th><th>d</th><th>e</th><th>f</th><th>g</th></tr><tr><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td></tr><tr><td>1. Participation in classroom discussion and activities</td><td>20%</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td></td><td></td></tr><tr><td>2. In-Class Presentation</td><td>25%</td><td></td><td>✓</td><td></td><td></td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td></tr><tr><td>3. Preliminary Analysis of Final Project</td><td>15%</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td></td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td></tr><tr><td>4. Final Project: Case Study</td><td>40%</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td></td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td></tr><tr><td>Total</td><td>100 %</td><td colspan="7"></td></tr></table>	Specific assessment methods/tasks	% weighting	a	b	c	d	e	f	g								1. Participation in classroom discussion and activities	20%	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓			2. In-Class Presentation	25%		✓			✓	✓	✓	3. Preliminary Analysis of Final Project	15%	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓	✓	4. Final Project: Case Study	40%	✓	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓	Total	100 %								The subject is assessed entirely through coursework and participation. Each assessment requires students to apply theories and concepts learned in the course to understand, reflect on and analyze real-life language and communication phenomena to gain insight into its implications for the worker and the workplace. The course is designed to train students to critically analyze intersections between language policy, society, economics, and communication. While working with partners, students will learn from each other about different strategies for approaching the learning tasks.
	Specific assessment methods/tasks			% weighting	a	b	c	d	e	f	g																																																				
	1. Participation in classroom discussion and activities	20%	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓																																																								
	2. In-Class Presentation	25%		✓			✓	✓	✓																																																						
	3. Preliminary Analysis of Final Project	15%	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓	✓																																																						
4. Final Project: Case Study	40%	✓	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓																																																							
Total	100 %																																																														
Student Study Effort Expected	Class contact:																																																														
	▪ Lectures	39 Hrs.																																																													
	▪ Seminars	0 Hrs.																																																													
	Other student study effort:																																																														
	▪ Class Reading/Preparation	28 Hrs.																																																													
	▪ Preparation for presentation and final project	40 Hrs.																																																													
Total student study effort		120 Hrs.																																																													
Reading List and Reference:	Readings may be drawn from the following sources: Duchêne, A., & Heller, M. (2012). Pride and profit: Changing discourses of language, capital and nation state. In A. Duchêne																																																														

	& M. Heller (Eds). <i>Language in Late Capitalism: Pride and Profit</i> (pp. 1-21). New York: Routledge. Gonçalves, K. & Schluter, A. (2024). Multicompetence as essential and English-language proficiency as secondary: Examining the shape of customer-employee interactions between speakers who do not share a common language. In <i>Domestics talk: Communication and social practices in a multilingual, migrant-run workplace</i> (pp. 100-113). Multilingual Matters. Gonçalves, K. & Schluter, A. (2017). Please do not leave any notes for the cleaning lady, as many do not speak English fluently”: Policy, power and language brokering in a multilingual workplace. <i>Language Policy</i> 16, 241-265. Heller, M. (2010). The commodification of language. <i>Annual Review of Anthropology</i>, 39, 101-114. Holmes, J., & Wilson, N. (2022). <i>An Introduction to Sociolinguistics</i>. Routledge. Kleifgen, J. A. (2013). <i>Communicative Practices at Work: Multimodality and Learning in a High-Tech Firm</i>. Bristol, UK: Multilingual Matters. Kusters, A., Spotti, M., Swanwick, R. & Tapio, E. (2017). Beyond languages, beyond modalities: Transforming the study of semiotic repertoires. <i>International Journal of Multilingualism</i> 14 (3), 219-232. Li Wei (2018). Translanguaging as a practical theory of language. <i>Applied linguistics</i> 39 (1), 9-35. Lorente, B. P. (2012). The making of “Workers of the World”: Language and the language brokerage state. In A. Duchêne and M. Heller (eds.) <i>Language in Late Capitalism: Pride and Profit</i> (pp. 183-206). New York and Oxon, U.K.: Routledge. McElhinny, B. (2015). Language and political economy. In N. Bonvillain (ed.) <i>The Routledge handbook of linguistic anthropology</i> (pp. 279–300). London and New York: Routledge. Otsuji, E. & Pennycook, A. (2010). Metrolingualism: Fixity, fluidity and language in flux. <i>International Journal of Multilingualism</i>, 7, 240–254. Piller, I. & Lising, L. (2014). Language, employment, and settlement: Temporary meat workers in Australia. <i>Multilingua: Journal of Cross-Cultural and Interlanguage Communication</i> 33 (1-2), 35-59. Pujolar, J. (2020). Linguistic entrepreneurship: Neoliberalism, language learning and class. In L. Martín Rojo and A. Del Percio (eds.) <i>Language and Neoliberal Governmentality</i> (pp. 113-134). London and New York: Routledge.
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	Strömmer, M. (2021). Intensified and insecure work of mobile cleaners: Tracing temporal cycles of seasonal cleaning work in a booming tourism destination. In K. Gonçalves and H. Kelly-Holmes (eds.) <i>Language, global mobilities and blue-collar workplaces</i>. (pp.187-203). New York: Routledge. Urciuoli, B. (2008). Skills and selves in the new workplace. <i>American Ethnologist</i> 35 (2), 211-228. Vine, B. (2009). Directives at work: Exploring the contextual complexity of workplace directives. <i>Journal of Pragmatics</i>, 41, 1395–1405.
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Revised by Prof. Anne Schluter (March, 2026)